Appendix A. A Quick Guide to Pseudo-Code

For this book we decided to use pseudo-code to describe how algorithms work. This decision was mainly motivated by two considerations:

- We wanted to make the book accessible to readers with all kind of backgrounds, without being tied to a particular programming language or paradigm;
- By providing a generic description of the steps performed by the algorithm and abstracting away low-level details, we can focus on the essence of the algorithms without worrying about programming language quirks.

The whole point of pseudo-code should be to provide a generic, complete and easy-to-understand description of algorithms; hence, if it is done properly, there should be no need to further explain it.

At the same time, even pseudo-code uses arbitrary conventions and needs to be consistent and well defined; moreover, readers that are not familiar either with this approach or with the notations or conventions chosen, might initially need some time to adjust and get to speed.

For this reason, we decided to add a short guide explaining the notation we are going to use throughout the book. If you